

Thomas Metzinger ~ Active Inference Insights 021 ~ Pure Awareness, Self-Models, Transparency

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hello everyone and welcome back to active inference insights I your host Daris parv Wayne and today I am truly honored to be speaking to one of this Century's most important philosophers Professor Thomas metzinger Thomas is Professor emiritus of theoretical philosophy at Johannes Gutenberg University of Minds co-founder of the German effective altruism foundation and president of the barbar vengera foundation in 2019 he found founded the minimal phenomenal experience or MP project and just this year released the book The Elephant and the blind which details the results of that project bringing together more than 500 experiential reports to offer the world's first comprehensive account of states of pure Consciousness his work focuses on Consciousness and he is best known for establishing the self model theory of subjectivity Thomas Professor matzinger we've we've spoken on email we've had our sort of you know we've had our email friends but it's actually so lovely to kind of see you or be it virtually um so thank you so much honestly it's an absolute honor and anyone who knows me knows that I'm a massive fan of yours I mean in the latest version of the flow States paper it has met singer 2003 2004 2005 2 and so on yeah something wrong with you thanks for having me anyway no well well it's one of those things I mean with respect to your work I feel like the past year has been sort of half active influence half met singer um so recipe for disaster but let's look at it no no it's why it's being fun I mean let I think a good place to start for the audience is to kind of out before we get into the new book because I do want to touch on that is to First outline the self model theory of subjectivity the smt because um it might strike people as initially rather counterintuitive so perhaps you could just give a brief account of the fundamental um claims or axioms of the smt with respect to its kind of key constraints whether that's transparency globality and so on yeah so in the Anglo-Saxon World there is this absolutely unreadable 2003 book um being no one this actually has a precursor most of you will not know in the German system we have two major thesis we have a PhD thesis and 5 years later we have a habilitation thesis which is a much bigger thing my

committee was 17 people wow and in 1993 I published a book called subject on self model um sub the subject and self model and the subtitle was the perspectival of phenomenal States from the perspective of a naturalist theory of mental representation so this already tells you what this is actually about um so being in the Consciousness Community I'm one of the guys that founded the ASC in 1994 I was always of the opinion that Consciousness is not one problem but a whole bundle of problems some more empirical some more conceptual and that the center the most difficult uh thing is what is a first person perspective what makes a state a subjective state in any given information processing system so I set out to tackle this and then 10 years later I had um a wonderful year one of the two best years in my academic career at UC San Diego where uh Paul and Patricia Churchland had hosted me was absolutely great in the philosophy and the cognitive science department and I wrote the whole thing in English and updated it in that year in the eighth floor of the HSS building Humanities and social sciences and I thought you can't do that title Americans need something more crude yeah yeah I said call the book being no one and uh that is what you have now uh and the idea this is indirectly it's also trying to make a contribution to the problem of Consciousness but the idea is to say what is a first person perspective really because everybody in Neuroscience or in philosophy talks about for instance like Dave Traas would be One PP facts and three PP facts but the notion of a first person perspective is taken as a conceptual primitive as if we all knew what that is but um it's actually a hybrid metaphor so you have the first person pronoun and there is a lot of good work in analytical philosophy of mind on you know if there's some irreducibility in um indexical expressions like I myself that's so that's so to speak the linguistic the surface level and perspective is a term from another discipline geometry you know people who work in Geometry can tell you something about what a perspective is parallel lines meet in infinity and and so on and so forth but together you know one could say it is the epistemic perspective that a system gains if it can refer to itself in the first person singular if it can use say an expression like I by saying I'm particularly happy and relaxed right now ascribe a phenomenal state to itself but then this would exclude all systems that can't use language all higher vertebrates and animals and well I developed we we can go what I really think a first person perspective is I think it's a model of the intentionality relationship maybe we can come back to this later and in my own to make the connection to active inference so I'll I'm much older than you are I'm 66 years now for me the first really first big intellectual Revolution was to discover Anglo-Saxon analytical philosophy of mind and get out of this Continental swamp I grew up in you know in the Frankfurt philosophy department and I'm very grateful to the older philosophers

um people like Peter beiri and so forth who is already already died um who poisoned young German philosophers by importing Anglo-Saxon analytical philosophy of mind where we discovered wow you know we've had this military catastrophe and everything in the century but in other places on the planet philosophy has gone on you know we just had total Destruction in in our country for decades and lost our intellectual Traditions teacher disciple relationships so I I really went into analytical uh philosophy of mind uh that's one thing another thing is taking conscious experience really seriously um because it was kind of ignored by mainstream Neuroscience a third element is um opening analytical philosophy of mind to neuroscience and cognitive science to organize interdisciplinary cooperation and then maybe the second or third um really intellectual revolution in my life was um connectionism and neuron networks and uh you know this you have and Clark um micro cognition 1989 uh in your country was super seminal and important for us and early work of Paul Churchland also and subsymbolic representation you know this whole debate photo compositionality and all this was very interesting and when car came out in 2010 um I've made a decision for myself that I'm too old that I'm not I'm just not going to get go into this on a formal level so when I in for instance the 2003 book use the term model mental model uh it is not a model in that terminological framework so as I say in the prease this is all just introduction to the self model theory of subjectivity the first inspiration I mean of course Roots Run deeper but um there is a book by Philip Johnson L that was called mental models um about relational data structures and there's a tradition in theories of mental representation in into which we looked very deeply in German philosophy maybe 20 years ago we discussed very deeply different models of mental representation and their history and there was a guy in 1943 Kenneth Craig who wrote a book the nature of explanation and there you have for the first time that's the classical Locus for the notion of a model a mental model relational data structure that have a partial homomorphy to the Rel know structure of what they represent so that's where the term self model came from me there there's a lot of technical stuff there diagrammatic reasoning right how how can system think with image like structures and not with symbol calculus you know that's where it comes from and step one I think there three major steps maybe step one was to apply this to conscious self representation and say okay there must be something like a phenomenal self model Beyond you know linguistic representation by mental models the whole technical Universe there um the second thing is the notion of transparency which actually originated in your very own country with GE Moore uh to apply this to the idea of a phenomenal self model um and ask what would happen to a system if not the external model

of the world were transparent meaning could not be experienced as a representation if it could if it operated under a model of itself a global integrated model of itself that was transparent which the system itself could not um experience as a representation as an internal representation and then the third step is what does it need in addition to do these two things to generate a consciously experienced first person perspective because you can imagine some systems human beings who are say completely conscious Wide Awake who have a self model say a robust body model say some states of stupor or total absent-mindedness or something like this but who do not have a subjective perspective on the world in any interesting sense at least they don't experience they may have one in epistemological Reading but phenomenologically they are not directed to the world as knowing self and what what is the difference there and um well I think it's that systems like us even model the intentionality relationship we can postpone that um so there I try to construct a theory a naturalist Theory how something like consciously experienced firstperson perspective could have naturally evolved what else do you think listeners should know about the self model so the main point is everybody thinks this is a theory of Consciousness no the aim was to have a conscious experience of subjectivity yeah yeah okay so so okay the thing is there's plenty there's plenty and I think um in my experience is that the the Notions have been developed uh chronologically in some ways like I sense there's a focus in your work towards uh the epistemic agent model the epistemic self model in the sort of 2013 2014 meeting Gary and stuff yeah yeah but I want to go all the way back I think a really good place to start for people in my experience was the prey to being no one which is this 2005 paper um so there there you talk about simulation and emulation and I think that's a nice place to start which is that in self models we have an emulating and simulating system and a Target system and it just so happens in the self model those things are the same and so I've always thought about with your work the kind of notion of a strange Loop or recursivity such that there's a part of our information processing system that is targeted at itself such that it simulates and by simulates you mean um reflects or uh the output of the information processing system and emulates the properties and states of that information processing system now I don't think people will necessarily have an issue with that right this goes all the way back to uh cybernetics control regulator theorem I guess what people might say is okay I have a model of myself and I in the sense that model is embedded in a world model so I'm also doing the same thing with respect to uh the world why is it that that process C of simulation and emulation is giving rise to phenomenality why is it giving rise to subjective uh experience and

if we can pass these two things out the what it is like to be a conscious being so why again it's it's a hard problem question but I guess um yeah yeah yeah I know what it's worth asking just to get R to the nuts and bolts what is it about that simulation and emulation act well so I think a simulation if I if I first generate a simulation of you I will simulate observable properties that my receptor systems what I can see and hear of you your my my visual representation of you my auditory representation I can simulate that then I can discover that you have unperceivable invisible features too namely that you are also a simulator and I might simulate those properties of you psychological properties mental properties if you want to put like a which are not observable by this kind of sensorium this kind of animal which I am has so I can in mind reading for instance human beings can simulate each other and they can emulate each other now the interesting thing is the reflexive case I can have a body model that's trivial and I can also somehow simulate abstract properties of mine that's where it already gets interesting like are there actually I mean there's the inceptive self model but that's receptor based what are these mental properties of myself for instance I may take myself to be a person I live in a culture in a society where we know the status of a person and I know this and then somehow I represent myself as a person as a rational individual that would be a very high level emulation now does any of this need to uh be conscious I don't think so that's um that's the million dooll question of course um I think that the largest part of the human self model is unconscious and the question is what is if we take the global workspace metaphor as a like as a proxy for a theory of Consciousness what part of the self model this organism has is currently globally available what part of the self model for instance can voluntary attention be directed to and what can you not direct your attention to what is what part is available for Selective motor control to which parts of myself can this itself can this animal point and I think most of the knowledge the really robust knowledge is of course unconscious so what your colleague George Dean would call the homeostatic control model which I think George has this very nice differentiation between an allostatic control model and a homothetic control model I think that's very useful and making those different levels in a human self model more precise and of course most of homeostatic control is totally unconscious um you know breath heartbeat blood body temperature and in a sense that's a self model but it's not a phenomenal self model and what is that part that needs to be elevated to Global availability what are the so to speak the functional the neurocomputational properties that any given moment Mark out the phenomenal partition I have no answer to this but uh I think that's the research question so I don't think that you magically um like pull yourself out of swamp by having a strange Loop

trick of self-referentiality and then the lights go on you become conscious um as I've tried to demonstrate for people who didn't know it in that new book um non egoic selfawareness without a firsters perspective is a widespread phenomenon that we know Consciousness can experience without a phenomenal self and Consciousness can exist with a subject object distinction without any experience of being directed as a knowing self as the world these are not necessary conditions so it might be something entirely itself I have wild speculative ideas but nothing I could really argue for yeah I I I will I definitely want to get into that um I I guess a point of clarity for people is that um would should the So when you say that when when it's written that the emulating simulating system and the target system are identical is to mean that they are uh strictly identical in the sense that if we took the neurocognitive mechanisms right if we just went to the physical level they would be the same or do we think that there's a higher order Network in uh organisms that possess a self model that is solely reserved for the act of simulating and emulating that's an interesting question and that that's where it gets very tricky um so I think of course I think the phenomenal self model uh that is currently active in your brain right now is strictly identical with some physical subset of your brain properties probably it's best be described on a functionalist level as a computational a Time slice in a computational um process so it's not identical with you as a whole with Darius as a whole um the idea is rather from an epistemological perspective the subject is the organism as a whole to achieve knowledge conscious knowledge about itself that organism has developed a neurocomputational tool that tool is the phenomenal self model but that's physically of course that's just a part of its nervous system physically so it's like the whole organism kind of refers or represents the whole organism consciously through a special part it has a physical part so in if that picture is roughly right um then saying they are identical is is not true it's it's like the epistemic subject what has that conscious self knowledge and the intentional object that what it is directed at that's identical in both cases it's the organism as a whole but the tool that's being used is something in its brains only a physical part I don't does it make things clearer or is that confusing um no I think it makes it clearer for me um God knows who it makes it clear for um I guess people all might also be thinking especially if they're uh neuroscientists let's say that all that exists in the nervous system is are these electrical signals uh in which there is no inherent distinction between the self and the world absolutely there's just sort of zeros and ones let's say how I mean does this require another computational mechanism to do the distinguishing I mean as you know this is a a classic problem in cognitive neuroscience and Phil of mind right like the So-Cal self specifying process yes is there something about self

modeling because maybe this is worth explaining as well that the self model is always embedded in a world model is there a way in which the system that's emulating and simulating itself does not take itself to be the whole world because if it you know the whole world is almost encapsulated embodied within the nervous system such that it can be phenomenally represented how does the system managed to make it distinction between itself and its lived world that's very important and a lot of things need to be said there um maybe as kind of a preface um we have to distinguish levels of description for instance a self model as described on the representational level of description which something which has a content and the content is the system as a whole or a self model that is described on some functional level of description say more fine grain computational level of description by the causal structure uh and um that will be some computational process uh in the nervous system and then of course at any given moment there will be a neurobiological implementation and there's a whole story which I exclude for now about inter subjectivity and social environments and and all of this and in making this distinction over the years I've I've these distinctions I found a very important one that gets many people confused is um the um the distinction between a computational self model and a phenomenal self model so there's this intuitive notion ah thisy is talking about the ego and what I experience as myself the egoic phenomenal self model there are special cases where it's not entirely like that but in general oh yeah what I I'm this thinking walking body controlling feeling self that's a phen the phenomenal self model we have quite often during waking States now if we look at the computational self model model then technically and we just look at conscious representation exactly what you said now is right all of the world which I now experience as being external to me is technically an internal State it's a virtual model it's a prediction about what might happen next on many different levels so what it actually is is as I said in my popular book the ego tunnel it's like the walls of the ego tunnel it's like a a surface but not a two-dimensional surface a very high dimensional membrane or Surface in that model with colors objects sounds and stuff like this and um in that in that respect it's a holy internal Affair and the puzzle consists in so if this is all an internal process why is it so robust ly experienced as the environment as the external uh reality of the system how does it make uh that distinction and one aspect is what am I the obvious cause of as you have written yourself you know what what is the the domain which is highly predictable and which I can control that's a candidate uh for what becomes the self model but computationally and if we just talk about Consciousness thing the whole thing this whole room the screen with your face my face that's a self model because it's a prediction of likely

own States um that may it's an anticipation you know uh so in that sense it is neither that's also interesting it's a probability distribution in that sense it's neither real nor unreal it is that's what I mean by virtuosity you know it's strictly speaking it's not real it's all a massive very complex hypothesis at every uh single moment so how is this so fundamentally split first thing to say I think is is we have especially in the light of say the last 10 15 years of theorizing get away from this simplistic self-worldotomy if this whole story about Markov blankets and so forth is true there are many nested Markov blankets uh and there are many statistical boundaries a living system creates for instance in its unconscious self-organization and Elementary bioregulation internally uh to the to the organism but I can well imagine that in this active inference framework when I actually do change something in the body external world and try to make the world conform uh to some internal Target state or something um there must be one really well defined No Nonsense no woo woo phenomenology Feelgood stuff where in saying that the human self model pulsates across the boundaries of the organism you know it sometimes dynamically runs Loops uh through the environment and I think it would be a major achievement if we could say all this in a formally uh precise way yet all the time I'm a very old-fashioned guy it I think it remains true that phenomenal properties locally super on neurofunctional properties in the brain that what is consciously experienced even in skillful embodied interaction with the world is fully determined by local neural activity in the brain you know even if the system develops a complex causal Loop through the environment conscious experience the phenomenality as such is locally constituted locally generated identical uh to a local process I would say and if that is true we might in the end arrive at a situation where people say ah Consciousness is so uninteresting you know it's just you know no but then these larger bubbles so bubbles they might be theoretically much more interesting maybe than that local model in the brain last thing let me just last I have often ask myself the question you just put to me what is the origin of self models asked people I mean and I think a really good candidate that is the immune system um it's a lowlevel very lowlevel process and it's super efficient you know we develop more than thousand malignos cells every day and your immune system shoots every single one down every day else you wouldn't be here it's a very old process it's very complex it's not localized in the nervous system but this um process is one of the first processes I think that draws a boundary between this is me and this is not me there are even even people who speak about an immune self and uh I think out of these entirely unconscious processes of trying try to maintain the boundaries of a living organism this is where it slowly grew up grew out of you know from a molecular level and um then of

course did you come to the in the new book did um did you come to that notion of the single embodiment constraint no I haven't okay there's a and then I working my way slowly through it yeah lot of people presently do um so uh this is something I want to point out because it's a constraint which is so simple that most people Overlook us Overlook it we human beings most animals are beings where all effectors and sensors are located in a narrowly circumscribed space of physical space space location in physical space we have a single embodiment we have a single skin surface pretty well defined we are highly local beings we could imagine um an artificial intelligence which has become conscious which administers administrates a few thousand robots with s and effectors or uh of their own all over the planet on the surface of other planets that AI could look through the windows of many single embodiments local embodiments of robots without actually itself having a single embodiment it could develop a very different kind of self model or mental properties than we have but we are just these local entities so for us it's very obvious physically localized in a single embodiment all almost you know sensors and effectors all concentrated in one location in physical space so the body model the physical organism model what can it do where can it climb how fast can it run this would also naturally have been something with a pretty simple boundary in space and so on and so forth I'm just trying to point out logically this wasn't necessary there could have been completely different intelligent creatures somewhere else in the universe widely distributed or something yes it's a fault experiment that I guess um is in some sense uh impossible to conceive because of the boundedness of our perspective perspective that's interesting isn't it well maybe it isn't I mean maybe I can't I mean I've been reading a little bit of Peter Godfrey Smith um B the pop science on octopuses octopodes and he speaks a little bit about these kind of you know the fact that octopuses seem to have um a far more distributed cognitive system which could imply multiple self models you know one for each arm I think what's interesting here is that thus far everything you said would be highly convergent with the with the Fluffy continentalists so um get we'll get there because um as I as you know I'm very interested in these kind of self- specifying processes yes so this is the work that really blossoms out of Dorothy lon's really wonderful sort of five years which he's just writing these incredible articles about selfs specifying processes and thus far I think you know what you're saying makes perfect sense which is that you know her and Evan and um others have said you know one of these self- specifying processes will be these efferent reafferent Loops uh and that is self selfs specifying because the cognitive system in some ways recognizes a signal that's caused by its action and a signal that's caused by the world yes and then the other thing

interestingly is actually in that 2011 tiex paper um specifying the self for cognitive Neuroscience they also talk about something akin to what you were uh mentioning with respect to the immune system which is that homeostasis uh might itself be a self non-self um specifying function absolutely because it's a self that's um maintaining its Integrity over a precarious world now the tension I think lies in this self as subject self as object distinction okay uh and this is where I you know this is where I've really been digging in and and trying to really get to the let's go there if you want to well I I I only briefly want to touch upon it because I think that Iron would have an issue with this notion that at its very bare minimum what you would call the minimal phenomenal selfhood what she would call the self as subject or pre-reflective self awareness can be representational yeah rather she would propose that and I think people like Dan Harvey and Shan Gallagher and going all the way back to SRA and moo Ponte that these are just uh this is just the subjectivity that's imminent in all experience yeah and it structures the world which it intends if that makes any sense um how can you main so how can you get pre-reflective self-awareness self a subject uh and keep your representationality uh how how do you make those two marry this brings up I'm going to share an anecdote with you so many years ago Francisco Varela you know and all these guys they have these this dogmatic dogmatic thing they don't know what they mean when they talk about representationalism but they know representations are bad and it is something rigid a represent and a representat and it's a rigid relationship and it could never be alive and all that so Francisco Vila invited me and David Chamas to um Paris to give talks and then he listened to myself talk and and he came to me afterwards and he said Thomas everything you say is Absolut right I can subscribe to everything but you're totally lost as as long as you don't uh give up your representationalism you yeah you're doomed and of course this is nothing new they all say that but what they haven't properly followed this intellectual tradition is I mean the concept of representation has developed veloped over some 350 years and and people you know dick hard Mal bran and people have thought about it and I think only a very small uh part of the Continental phenomenology tradition have even grasp uh neural networks and the fluidity and context sensitivity of neural networks and dynamical systems and all this stuff we cognitive science has been through um representations can be something very much alive and super context sensitive you know and uh it's I think it's very obvious that our concept of representation is evolving if you think you know um of the whole predictive processing framework how it is evolving but personally I'll just tell tell you what my personal uh stance on this is the representational list so I'm an instrumentalist and but not a realist about

representations I make no statement if anything like that exists in the world met physically all all I'm saying is at this stage of scientific progress wherein last 40 years maybe modern cognitive science the concept of representation which is being continuously enriched and calibrated and refined uh you may remember that in being no one you know I talked about presentation representation simulation all that is still useful it is still juristically Fant to use that level of description but there will be some stage in scientific progress where we probably discard this uh and and say okay now let's say a cards model goes through somebody will say okay it's now all a part of statistical physics or something like this we Notions of content uh of Notions of a belief or Notions of a model how ever technically refined is not something we need anymore we can do it all on a lower level of description and I mean the super frightening question is of course if this could happen to phenomenology itself you know to Consciousness yeah people would eliminate that concept because they have more fine grain lower level uh concept so I'm not wedded to the representationalist level of description but I still things and that brings us back to our conversation also I still think um it is very useful for instance speaking in terms of models and self models still and say well now we mean something more predictive processing is by it and not something Johnson Lish by it yeah although one can see if one looks there's an intellectual tradition there this is not disjunct right so MPS um yeah you know there's I should shouldn't say much because I haven't properly read that literature but there is this it has the MPS paper in 2009 was very influential and then people have made their own naively realistic branches of it and he kept talking of the minimal self and a minimal self as if there was a thing and maybe I don't know if that's relevant but one also has to be aware that this whole issue of self is of course ideologically charged um there will be a group whenever you say something about your ideas Darius there will be a group in your audience who are Buddhists and say yeah yeah yeah yeah yeah no self I've always wanted to be you know and there will be another group who has a strong desire for mortality denial and there something that is irreducible or some ideological things so um and it cannot be true that there is not something that is Untouchable by science or by philosophical analysis for many people that's emotionally very important and that puts a lot of noise on the signal for instance I think most of the criticism and re uh react uh resentment I've got in my own country in Germany was not by you know Catholics or people who want a metaphysical notion of self but by very good leftists who thought this is dangerous because it erodes the Revolutionary subject and they didn't read you know but you know the idea sure they didn't read it properly they didn't understand these things but they said this is kind of dangerous we need the rational critical

subject the subversive subject and yes good luck um well I just don't well my well I I mean that sounds almost quite Catholic in some sense that you're invoking some kind of cartesian uh thing onto itself that that can make itself revolutionarily and subversive I'm I'm in some sense interested in a far more stripped down form of selfhood such that I don't even like using the word I'm more interested in subjectivity okay I guess no no and it's totally fine I mean I mean um there's a I just think for people there's a nice very nice Stanford encyclopedic article by Zahavi and Gallagher about self-consciousness and there they kind of talk about how deflationary we should take this notion of pre-reflective self-awareness to be and I'm quite interested in this very sort of to the point where the notion of self itself kind of disintegrates such that you're left with as I said the subjectivity imminent in experience I'm just curious in your when you write um that sorry footnote before you go on yeah I of course know this article I was always much too lazy to submit one of my own but this article uh in in the SCP is is a political move it's very clear that it is a political move to establish a certain view on on self-consciousness and exclude others it's not very balanced and of course there is would you agree and I understand this of course I emotionally understand it do you under agree that there is an anti-reductionist resentment in this there must be something you know that's un Noble Untouchable um perhaps perhaps I'd have to go and read it more with with respect to that question I have to go read it a little bit more acutely I mean I'm personally I mean maybe this is the product of being an early career I mean I'm not even in a career but let's say like an early level researcher that I'm quite Keen to remain agnostic about the big questions um interesting well also because I don't want to piss people off um and who am I to piss off you or Dan Harvey or Sean G right we all no no we can we can all be friends um I think that said I mean in terms of the sociology of Consciousness I think there is been a slight push back against I think you're right there's been a slight push back maybe for ideological reasons and I think some of it probably is something like Terror management um against the iru against the reducibility of Consciousness I I I think that's certainly true I mean I'm recognizing even in the conversations I am having a far greater willingness to invoke at least for hypothetical reasons something like dualism and that's interesting um again I'm quite agnostic I think that I won't say that Consciousness is reducible and I won't say Consciousness is irreducible um I guess I take I I'm not I don't know about the ontology and I also um and my my my limitations with the ontology in many ways the limitations of my epistemology right like I it could be it really could be that it's all neur networks and neural firings um I just don't know and so I'm quite happy to remain silent where I where I don't know I guess the question I was going to ask is

you say that um the content of experience is representational content and I'm just curious about whether you would say that pre-reflective self-awareness so the sense that is not intended but is there that experiences for you is a content of experience uh it's um it's well it's never really clear what pre-reflective means you know there's a lot in German idealism in fact we have our own local discussions of this with people like d Henrich and so on what this pre element really is in which everything is grounded and it's in what sense is it pre is it that what comes first when you come to after birth is it in a temporal sense pre reflecting about yourself as a subject or is it something deeper is it some transcendental a condition of possibility for everything else if that's or is it because the condition of person uh possibility itself will not be something phenomenal this will not be something you experience but I think there may be an interesting way out there that some creatures can internally represent the conditions of possibility say for having a first person perspective but of course not in words concept or propositionally but in an entirely you know Subs symbolic format this is the enabling condition for things more complex States I will have later and um the the question is I think your question is would can or do we want to describe this as a representation I mean if it is something that is if the claim is this is something everybody can consciously experience I mean this is somehow the claim you all know this pre-reflexive element Um this can of course be doubted like you mean the same thing when you refer to it and dorot means the same thing and I mean the same thing of my attempt has always been to go deeper than that or make that more precise I pretty much know what they mean and it's a long broad tradition from from satra and so forth and German idealism fish and all all that um but what is it actually to take it seriously and not just keep saying as a placeholder pre reflect so the real German term is and that in English means something like pre-reflexive self-intimacy there's a way of being intimate with yourself way before any thoughts or concepts appear yeah that's what I'm also interested in uh and I don't know if you would agree but being self intimacy is is an epistemic notion somehow you know yourself somehow you are always already in touch with yourself you know and I've been um you know very interested in what the sources of this are and I think if you look at it there's more than one source actually so for instance I don't know the French um so in in Malo ponti has this point they take this distinction of um body kper Cara by the way relates to the English word corpse know that's the inanimate body and the lived body and um Malo ponti made a very interesting point about what in German is called that means means there is one signal Source in the self model which is permanent something like the proceptive self model and the inceptive self model which is like the background hum of

your refrigerator which is so invariant that you don't hear it anymore until the refrigerator goes off and there is something in the phenomenology the interior perception of One's Own body um that has permanence and I think that permanence is responsible for some of the cartesian intuitions that not only you have but that I have too because I think in English you say a substance uh is ontologically self-subsistent I think I think that's the the right term you would use sounds about right yeah so a substance if the self was a substance it would be something that could hold itself in the state of existing even if everything else in the universe would disappear that's a metaphysical substance now we find that in our phenomenology I think this experience Maro ponti pointed to is it's an experience of not only being very deeply intimate and in touch with myself but continuously holding myself in existence and what I find so fascinating this is exactly what Carl talks about when he speaks about predicting yourself into existence we are actually yeah maybe you guide me I talk no it's just I no no no that that face was only because I've been reading so much L and she's obviously influenced me um met no I haven't I mean I I sort of I would love to I haven't even reached out to her um this is this has just been like it's been a bit of a whirlwind of me just reading her papers and being like Jesus Christ um I think I think in part because in the British educational philosophical curriculum you're taught that Consciousness involves necessarily qualia intentionality and subjectivity and so for someone to reinforce the uh subjectivity aspect I I don't you know it's like I'm flirting with objective Consciousness and subjective Consciousness and maybe it's just it was a nice reminder you know it sort of spurred up some childhood memories for me of learning about Consciousness okay I'll I'll I'll throw two things at you about cartesian intuitions um I have them too and intuition is something that gets in your way when you do philosophy because it is something that structure structures your model of reality now the human self model has a specially extended part the body model and it has layers which have no special properties namely if you do um if you calculate in your head or something like that if you do abstract reasoning the phenomenology is you're doing it it's mental action but it is not in space it is in time so it has some parts of the self model are spatially coded uh on the level of phenomenal experience and some only have temporal properties that makes this car the cart's argument about *res extensa* and *res cogitans* extremely intuitive for beings like us for beings with self models like us do you say chimes resonates with our um self-experience because we are indeed sometimes thinking things and you've written about it in your forthcoming paper that when we mentally act we automatically imply that there is an entity uh that can control in this way there's a controller and of course the same for um bodily movements um so that's why

cartesian intuitions are so plausible um they get in our way it there is something inconceivable uh in the truth of say physicalism or subjectivity only being a very high level irrelevant um property and uh in in this Oxford Handbook of the self I've I've written a chapter called um the no self alternative I try to explain why everybody necessarily has a feeling there is something wrong with no self scenarios because the very Act of trying to actively mentally simulate a possible World in which there was no self always generates a sense of effort and that sense of effort is the self you know yeah yeah yeah you you get my point it's well well sure I I mean for me that I don't I I wouldn't I don't know how much metaphysical import I would draw from that in that intuition um I guess so it cannot sorry for interrupting but cannot be true for beings like us it cannot be true could never be really intuitive level right I think I think that's absolutely right um well I guess my question here therefore is at the phenomenal level not the metaphysical level okay um I so I want to talk about your new book um but before I get into that so in your new book you show there's a kind of non- egoic zero person perspective um which implies that in some ways there's a it was well again I haven't read too much of it but it it sounds like to me that you that one could interpret that at least as the maintenance of a world model without a model yeah I'm curious about whether you before we get into that what about the inverse of that could you imagine that there could be a self model without a world model well absolutely I bring this up so first this new book which is open access available for everybody uh the English version um is not a scholarly monograph this is not like being no one it's more like a multi-level experiment in popular signs so I'm trying to the the it's it's really an experiment trying to inspire a lot of very different people at the same time which includes practitioners of meditation who may not have no interest in research uh or philosophers or even theologians to offer something to take it out of my hands so my ideal reaction to that book would be if many people say n nice try I can do this much better that would be my ideal result if people take these bits and teasers and do some proper um research somewhere now the question that occurs of course the in the phenomenology of mystical experiences non du awareness there's a a cluster of phenomenologies I'm trying to document there for some people the self expands um for instance it the phenomenology of identification can attach not to this body and not to The Thinker of these thoughts but to the all pervading quality of awareness as such um that's a well documented phenomenon in advanced practitioners of meditation so you can become the awareness but the question is there are long traditions in Asia who say that is the true self like ad vanta and there are long traditions like all the centuries of Buddhist philosophies philosophy will say no no no there is no such thing as a

self and uh if you would now let's just take speak phenomenologically about the phenomenology of identification the kind of phenomenal content of which you could after the experience say I was this because during the experience you typically cannot say I am this you cannot really say it right um so that phenomenology is there a phenomenology of identification with the whole with world or should we rather say these states are um neither self States nor World States you know because the distinction doesn't make sense anymore and you know there's this notion of nondual awareness in the contemplative Traditions that there are states of experience Global States modes of experience in which uh the distinction between subject and object makes no sense anymore so I quote one Advanced meditator from Israel at some place in the book who says it is not me looking it is the world looking so that the whole world becomes the epistemic subject The Knowing entity or something and as you very rightly point out we have this becomes a terminological issue some Mystics over the centuries will say I became one with the world I still wasn't there uh I still was there I expanded all embracing others will say um a description I very much like by one person was nobody sitting on the cushion everything sitting on the cushion uh he described this you know that like the whole world sits on the cushion but he's not there all the heavy um so that's a terminological question um the way I would like to frame it is that what was previously the the egoic phenomenal self model can in some rare cases become identical to the computational S self model we talked about earlier so so the whole thing becomes recapitulated into sort of phenomenal space yeah it's it but it's also as if these states were much closer to the scientific image of the world than the old biological model of reality with a s going through yeah yeah yeah no I mean of course yeah yeah so absolutely in terms of how neuroscientists take it it absolutely is consonant with that I guess my question here is again it comes back to this pre-reflective versus reflective dichotomy when we talk about the possession that these people experiencing uh expansive States Of Consciousness Oceanic feelings of consciousness at one month and so on are we talking so it sound like to me that actually The Possession in many ways is a pre-reflexive property of their experience such that uh the whole world is seeing is not I am seeing the whole world as mine yeah yeah yeah of course not is there so I wanted to recognize that there is a difference there because I think um I've done a bit of meditation not as seasoned as you or or someone like lar but in some ways I found that you know at those very glimpses of nonel awareness there is a kind of very subtle recognition that uh I would would the sense that I am not distinct from that which I am observing but in some ways that so that but that in some ways that is uh can be paradoxically flipped to mean that sort of I own

that as much as I own myself um there's just two meanings really of the word owning absolutely right yeah correct and so I'm just curious about is it really the case in all of these So-Cal zero perspective the owning is uh all you know emerges pre-reflectively or is there also a split where the possession is a reflective I own this thing like I own my car or I own my laptop I mean afterwards this is also true for psychedelic experiences um afterwards people will some people will just stay quiet and not report this and keep it as a treasure and most other people will run off and talk about it and they will talk about it in their belief system in given the conceptual instruments their culture their cult their spir you know their lineage their spiritual lineage their Master whatever their church has given them and that is actually what I'm calling attention to this phenomenology is almost ineffable and if we could make a little progress uh bring a little Clarity in there because it's so obvious that there is an elephant and different people describe that elephant in different ways and can we make I don't have the final Solutions can we make some conceptual progress in understanding this and one thing that will fall out naturally I think is that what these German idealists fish and um say people like Manfred Frank and daa Henri in Germany would call this pre-reflexive self intimacy and what you have in this satra uh this this whole story maloon uh tradition as pre pre-reflective self-awareness there's actually something slightly below this or it can be said more precisely and I call it non- egoic reflexivity because I think the really really interesting Discovery the Tibetan Buddhists have made I don't know maybe in the 12th century or so is that this experience of pure awareness has a quality of reflexivity in it sometimes but not always there's even a term called rri um self- knowing uh non- egoic awareness and I think that is probably the common phenomenological anchor for what all these philosophers try to home in on as pre-reflexive selfawareness but they do make the Mist take of still putting projecting some egoic character into it some yeah well well my intuition you know and there is no ego character in it yes is there is there perspectival I'm not the person to know but person I take very seriously is the world can be seen out of this so there is okay this is maybe I don't know getting too much but there is something that is called dual mindfulness and meditation researchers research where you would say sit on your cushion and have an experience of pure awareness and it's all nice and clear and silent but you're still having it there's a meditator who has pure awareness yeah yeah yeah yeah and then there is nondual mindfulness which is absolutely effortless no control therefore if my theory is right that the phenomenology of ownership is um called uh is caused by control controllability then it would not be going along with ownership as you said and uh I found it interesting sahav has at one point use that concept of anonymity also I think yeah

something that is really in that sense nameless and self not owned by anyone yeah uh yes and my suspicion is every human being actually if they are a little quiet and silent and they feel into it they can experience this non- egoic reflexivity in pure awareness they know what this is but then later to describe it leads to an explosion of philosophical system yes and poetry no but no not in a derogatory way uh I I mean poetry in the most complimentary way um I thought that some of the testimonies of these people were very beautiful so I mean that not at all in a in a demeaning way to their experience but they you see they most of them are not economic academics and they don't read things like you and I read um it's amazing how they yeah yeah about they do their best they do their best in natural language but the sexy question is of course if given mathematics and computational phenomenology we could go further we could have more precise descriptions maybe a perception in which in the end dor and TR galaka and everybody can say yeah that was what we meant yeah Thomas was right no not Thomas was right no I know I know but there's a the question is of course what are the criteria can we have any criteria I mean what would convince you in the end it's just people talking about their own phenomenology right it is and I wanted to ask about this autobiographical retrieval aspect but actually before I do I want to just ask about this reflexivity because I thought that was a very interesting point that some of this egoic awareness non-ic awareness rather is reflexive and some isn't now it seems to me that again there are multiple ways of disambiguating the term reflexivity yeah so one is a kind of reifying reflexivity um such that it becomes a thing that you own right so um this is my leg is clearly self-referential but it's also reifying right I can sort of dissect my leg as an object that belongs to me uh and actually I think Dorthy again is quite helpful here in her kind of analysis of uh dancers talking about their experience of their own bodies as performative and transparent rather than opaque such that they can take their body as an intentional object without reifying it through what she calls scrutiny so I'm curious to think about what it means for non egoic awareness to reflect on itself how can this be done in a manner which doesn't in turn rify uh the aware the the awareness itself pure awareness such that it sort of becomes an encapsulated notion that something is beyond so that has alterity with respect to something else that's a super interesting question and I'm I think you're just homing in on the Target and uh I think there's nothing you can do doing anything will always ruin it and as all meditators know if there's even the faintest Glimpse the noticing of this Glimpse very often ruins it um because it leads to the reification or some stray thought that says uh and as I quote one of our subject somewhere in the book who says very interestingly to me but is this pure awareness asks the thinking mind and something else just

knows oh you know that's how she describes it right something else just knows because it knows itself and of course it's non propositional and I mean there's a long tradition I have a small chapter on meditation and non-meditation who have always said over the centuries there is nothing you can do do not meditate uh one of the nicest present day installments of this is American meditation teacher I Kelly there's a three minute uh YouTube video which goes don't meditate marinate the whole idea is this is here it's established yeah don't the um try to grasp it or experience it because it's it's already here um and you have to if you can marinate in that quality which in more sober words I've called a phenomenal character of tonic alertness I think it may be something very B basal and very simple in the end namely just the quality of pure wakefulness as such and if you don't attempt to look at it subjectively but like rather dissolve in it marinate in it then maybe it can know itself through you or something like uh but it needs a lot of future research and the big question is of course also I mean what value do we assign to these experimental reports yeah many of these people are deep into bizarre belief systems you know they are way out of the scientific worldview some of them will not many but some of them will not be accessible to rational argument um and is that well there are two things there one is I'm gonna ask you something so if Doro says in there's a perfect flow moment in dancing where my body come becomes transparent so the body would always be transparent to use her word well apart from something in like a deafferented patient um by bodily transparency she she doesn't really mean what you mean by transparency as you actually pointed out no that's different but if she the way she uses the concept of the transparent body yeah it's intuitive to you you have the feeling um I I I understand this notion of the world being presented in a bodily fashion aha that's really what she means so she she there's there's multiple so this for people who are curious is it's it's actually it's her and who is the other it's 2009 um there it is perceiving subjectivity in bodily movement LR and Raven R A VN uh I think Raven also wrote a fair bit about dancing um yes I think Dorothy was very much on to what we're talking about here in terms of flow States but she says um let's have a look let me I just want to make sure I don't take her words out of you know out of context or or speak on you know well I shouldn't be speaking to paraphrase Vicken Stein um but I will come to it in any case um footnote that there yeah yeah if you're interested in all of this um I would very much recommend the work of Adrian alith okay at um King's College are you aware of him I'm not he wrote an excellent thesis with me called the structuring body yeah and this is all about how the body structures the perceptual field or the phenomenal field Y and there's a lot you might be interested in there cool well I certainly well thank you I'll certainly

sent him I've just looked yes yes this notion of structuring is is is an interesting one I think I do understand it but I'm also I'm also to some degree concerned about how much I'm getting indoctrinated by the um by the Poetics of some of these papers such that I P if I just need did a title perceiving subjectivity I mean you can perception is object representation subjectivity is an abstract concept it invites uh trying to build a mental model of that uh of of of that sentence while trying to understand it can I perceive my own subjective yeah I can and no scientist is ever going to take this away from me you know what's funny is that you two you two thank each other so much in your like footnotes I I I I like her and she always came as a visitor to the Mind Group I think it's it's all very nice but if you want to take it seriously what does perceiving subjectivity mean does this does this make any sense conceptually well I think I think to be fair I would take the notion that that title is somewhat tongue and not tongue and cheek but it and it's it's certainly not lazy is certainly the wrong word but it's somewhat um it's somewhat deflationary uhhuh I think I think I I like this notion more of Perce I mean again I'm doing a rubbish job um but it's very important I think to contrast it with this with what she calls opacity and what she calls performativity um I think I may it may oh it may actually be the uh the Iron 2007 pre-reflective self-consciousness on being bodily in the world which was in Jana's head um it's funny I've been recommending these papers to everyone so sorry guys if you do put down the garden part you know and I recommend yours as well Thomas obviously um yes okay excellent um a transparent body pre reactivity experiences the bodily mode of givenness of objects in the external World okay this is yeah so 20 what they mean but I even say this in the Elephant book very briefly givenness G height there's the myth of givenness willf fire sellers the concept of givenness if we want to take it really really really seriously has strong theological connotations uh there are philosophers of religious religion who speak about the quality of givenness as the world is given to me my life is given to me by God and all that sure if we take this out Dar the letin Darius the Latin means to give that's a social relationship between person A and B so if you say there is a quality of givenness there there is an entity that has a personal level characteristic if I want to take that literally that gives something to me so the world is another somehow it is another self that reveals itself to me or gives it to me as a present that's I mean that's poetry uh that's beautiful I I think I can experience what is meant by this there are phenomenologies but conceptually it doesn't really make sense there is not a giving something to person B maybe it is much something much more like what bu Buddhists would call the quality of suchness that there is a self-revealing quality in in in inanimate objects which you can perceive if you look properly or something

like that that's speculative so I know no other way of taking what seor says seriously as trying to take it literally and then it explodes in my head well I guess the idea might be perceptual object I'm just very sorry you know the idea might be um the idea might be that um well okay so I will come to this notion of perceiving subjectivity because I have the paper now in front of me I think in terms of the givenness I mean I think again I'm not a historian of phenomenology uh this is all you know somewhat new given my age and whatnot but um I think some of it seems to be a linear AG from husel and this notion of givenness and then I think the other thing that feeds into it is and I think it probably is protor religious in some sense that it's intentionality or Consciousness giving its own contents to itself yeah and and then some ways it speaks to you know God as the Divine spark God as Consciousness and so on which is obviously a deeply judeo-christian idea yes do you have any of those I mean just also map on on some predictive processing generative model of reality in the brain right because this is also self-giving all the time of course it's confirmation bias in many ways um it's confirmation bias aha but well we seek we seek evidence for the priors that are you know encoded in our generative hierarchy I mean that's that's the B if we Remain the things that we are of course um I wondered whether you know that's that kind of claim that intentionality I I use it you know I think what we've kind of come to here is the importance and in many ways the opacity that language gives right when I say in Consciousness gives its own contents to itself I am constructing a kind of subject verb an SVO sentence which I could say for I eat a pizza right but I mean something clearly quite different here and I think in many ways of course it it rifies the subjects and the objects because that's language does and and so as you say many of these conversations end up being literally ridiculous um because it's it's very difficult to understand exactly what's being spoken about here but I think again there is a latent uh ontological commitment in something like that which is that uh Consciousness is in some ways an agent has some agentic Force to it that is not just a not just a uh a part of its phenomenology but perhaps also part of its ontology again I'm very much this is not what dor or Mur Ponte anyone says I'm just abstracting here somewhat you're you're I guess quite Keen to bracket out those ontological commitments right you this is not a theory of Consciousness per se uh how the simulation and emulation manifests into phenomenal space is somewhat the big question right it's traumas is hard problem is there anything in you that when you say there are no such things as selves is there any part of you which goes but I don't know because I don't know the the the true origin of experience yes of course I don't uh I might you know die in five minutes and no and there may be a roaring crowd of angels laughing at [Laughter] me

you know and there may be all these non-physical entities slapping their knees laughing loud and saying no look at yourself without a body it was all wrong you know uh uh many things could happen the next instant I I don't know idealism might turn out to be right in the end there are these also probably there are metaphysical options I think which in principle may always remain viable and of course it and you can if you take the whole self model Theory which has many layers something we haven't spoken about for instance completely is social self models self models in societies the resonating process between different uh subject you could turn it around and said if it allows you to sleep easily this is a theory about what selves are sell are intermittent processes that are absent in uh in dreamless deep I mean phenomenal self-d dreamless deep sleep which are very different and very volatile during the dream state the non- lucid dream state and which are sometimes on some layers are quite robust during waking and we know this and there probably like a self something like a self model and then if you look closer you find a that a lot of things you've always thought aren't true so a famous Point some meditators make if you actually attend to what is going on in your head and when you go about your normal business during the day you don't have to meditate there's very often there's no self there yeah well no absolutely absolutely well there's no uh it so depends on what you mean by the self I mean there's no self there's no self as what I call well you know the self as uh what did we call it reflect you know conceptual the self as a conceptual object I mean again I get into the Super granularity of this as you know in the footnotes um I've you know and people can read the footnotes of that flow paper and I think it's an attempt to really unpick if we hold this dichotomy of self as subject to self as object where does it uh linger and where does it diminish and here your work on mind wandering dreaming is super informative um I guess the response would always be well un you know underneath all of that still yes the loss of cognitive agency the loss of autonomous agency there is nonetheless the subjectivity imminent in experience and I well the reason why I asked this ontological question is I I one clarifying question do you mean underlying is a phenomenal experience of a really primordial let's say primordial subjectivity or are you saying the enabling conditions are always still there I can always come back I'm talking I I'm talking about the former okay I think I think think if there is experience if there again I need I I'm reticent to say it but I think if I I well at least I take seriously the claim that if there is experience there is pre-reflective self-awareness not just the enabling conditions for pre-reflective self-awareness there is a uh a subjective thickness a forness to all experience uhhuh that that's that that's the claim I'm making and I think the notion of this uh pre-reflective is the fact that it's enable it's note it's not

a pre- enabler of itself it's a pre- enabler of higher order forms of self-reflexivity yeah so it presupposes the very capacity for that but in some deflationary sense it's always there so when you get your self- reflexivity you've always got this sense that there is but again when I say there is a sense I don't mean a sense that you're intending that it's just there that that object is being intended for some one or something okay so let's just go through some examples so Darius has meditated and it has been more or less okay and then he gets up and he tries to do some walking meditation uh on the lawn and then something like a flow State happens and you can tell your listeners what exactly that implies lies suddenly the walking becomes completely effortless mhm and in a only attention is only in the present moment um there are no noticeable thoughts um is that for whom this you're trying to get up in that case is it something like the for this bod uh well in the sense of the walking meditation I would say that the subjectivity there is punctuated ultim or defined ultimately by a certain bodiliness not so much an embodiment but in bodiliness there's a sort of bodily thickness to the experience um yeah you know so and is that that you feel your guts and your heartbeat no it's not I know no no I wouldn't say it's as specific as that um there might be some people you know anal SE type might say well you always have this um buzzing of in you know viscera in you know and guts and the interceptive processes for me so I think there's an open question that I was going to ask you actually and I guess I have more questions more questions to you now I want to understand this so in being no one I I have also described this special I've made these neurop phenomenological case studies there are these kotar syndrome patients who will merely sit in a chair and claim that they are dead so they have no life no lived body but a corpse and I will even ask the doctors to throw that corpse away in saying that there is a forness still you think I I well it is you know kotar syndrome kot's delusion it's it's a I would I would I would I would tentatively suggest that it's still a delusion for whom in the same way as realization um which you know to be candid with everyone I have experienced a fair bit of um as a result of anxiety attacks and there is nonetheless a Fess in a derealized or depersonalize state okay more questions Darius has been stoned out of his mind again but he realizes he has to get home begins walking home the body walks home home while in a completely absentminded State um is there where's the forness hiding there so okay so I I think uh there is a point here that I think I I I can't answer currently which is whether pre-reflective self-awareness is always pre-reflective bodily self-awareness so I think that's a that's a that's an interesting question Darius is in dreamless deep Sleep yeah is there forness in dream is deep sleep no right no I would say you're just Darius is non lucidly dreaming is it for whus for the subject for the phenomenal

subject of my dreaming experience I would hold that there is a for whus within their experience okay now Darius reads a Buddhist treatise and comes to the conclusion formlessness is the root of all suffering I must think about the most efficient way to eliminate this what would he uh presumably I would probably start doing some vipassana and or maybe take some maybe take some DMT or something I don't know uh blow my brain my neurons apart so you would aim at what researchers called ego dissolution and then I would which I'm skeptical of I'm not saying I don't I'm not again I haven't read your entire book I I can't say yeah I'm I'm I'm purely skeptical of um this notion of I think I think there's a little section of the flow paper where we say okay there might be a a range of flow states which include psychedelic and meditative states such that you get something like the downregulation of the default mode Network and the loss of reflective self-awareness right like planning is prohibited meta self-conceptualization is prohibited and I I I sense that in some of my own meditative experiences and psychedelic experiences and Flow State experiences for that matter nonetheless um I think what people I think there's a risk or a suspicion that when people are talking about ego dissolution there is nevertheless a maintenance of subjectivity in their experience maybe brings us back to the question you still wanted to ask I mean a big epistemological issue I have there's a one very good paper about it by Rafael Miller I flagged know how why should we believe any auto fine phenomenological report about ego dissolution well I was going to ask that so I was curious about you know how can you coherently report a self a state of consciousness from autobiography your own autobiographical memory exactly so I see the issue there and there are some um attempts to get around it by saying autobiographical memory is constituted to a second order architecture but I think the somehow the claim somebody and that's the question the claims is making that they themselves were having a selfless experience during that period of time and that cannot be right somehow yes in some sense well yeah something's G to miss there so the linguistic IC Exposition is somehow faulty yeah if it was true this point I'm flagging and on which I have no how say no official final opinion this is of course an epistemological barrier for doing research on this because all people reporting things like that we should doubt them we should think yeah they had a a near selfless State and their confabulation because they want to have something so much you know they are Buddhist Pious Buddhist Believers and they want to report something they want to report an experience but the the question could be is there an unconscious autobiographical memory which was running and registering you know while there was a conscious selfless experience and which afterwards surfaced again that was by some unconscious mechanism that was a

selfless episode was registered then is made globally available again and then misdescribed by somebody who just doesn't know what to say about it and MISD describes it as their own experience um what would you yeah well I just I wonder whether even an unconscious memory doesn't in some way involve the self specifying process that's a good point that's a very good point right so I it might not only be an issue of the intentional you know the intentions of the subject such that you know I want to dece I want to confabulate I want I really want this to be true it may just be the very Act of a lived experience passing into memory transforms it yeah that's might be exactly right that in beings like us were as you said before self-specific mechanisms were so important from an evolutionary perspective also the retrieval process automatically structures the whole thing in some egocentric self-specific format it brings exactly exactly so I've only got a couple other questions I'm aware of time constraints um yeah keep going I hear lunch isn't ready yet so you you live a lovely life uh no it's tomorrow my term no there there's a there's a there's a slight mention again very early on in the book about uh intrinsic phenomenological essence of pure awareness so this kind of is there a unifying characteristic because in the book you sort of the structure in many ways is sort of the different features um of pure awareness so you have the kind of relaxation for example I believe is the first chapter and and there are others um do you what what's the kind of conclusion to that question about whether there's a intrinsic phenomenological Essence to Pure awareness well this is really just preliminary work it's it's more like creating a platform for other people to start from but there's a summary chapter in which I I have tried to extract five different readings of what Purity could mean you know because also different people mean different things by it and I'm also this right at the beginning most meditators or um metaphysically minded people from India will hate what I'm saying my working hypothesis is that pure awareness is not pure um because it has a content right um and then the question the research question is what kind of content could be so simple and subtle that it makes it absolutely natural for people afterwards to say I experienced the character of awareness as such pwar what would that be and uh that's what I'm trying to answer so I don't believe I an anti-essentialist I don't think um you know this also metaphysically I don't do metaphysics but the whole idea of an intrinsic property which something processes in all possible contexts um I don't believe it I think there are only relational properties uh and only relational properties in the end also fit into the scientific scheme of explanation and knowing phenomena I think yeah so if there is as many claim an intrinsic Essence to awareness itself this would be a prime candidate for something that cannot be reductively explained by science a prime candidate

right yes it's its own sort of prime mover unmoved to you know go the way the way back to Aristotle um I guess um when when I think about um pure awareness I also think about pure Consciousness events Robert Foreman's work in the '80s um and I got in I've said this on the podcast before but I got sort of introduced to that by John Vu who I know you've spoken to um and John describes the way that Foreman describes pure Consciousness offense and I think in quite a poetic and beautiful way again in no ways uh do I mean poetic in any derogatory manner that um adjectival qualia is lost so bless redness warmth and so on but adverbial qualia remains and by that it means presence nowness heess potentially subjectivity I wanted to pick up on one of them which was uh nness or presence um you write I think I mean again these are the earlier works but you write quite explicitly that phenomenal States you know one of the constraints of them is this presentness um is it the case that phenomenal State experiences need to be experienced now and if so what does that mean I mean what does it Islander phenomenal experience seemingly to emerge yet not be distinct in some ways from the flow of time yeah this is where of course um we don't have any clear intuitions so um how to say my former research assistant Jennifer Wind who has written this fantastic book *Dreaming at M* press we have discussed a lot many years ago oh what the step from MPS to MP would be what one would have to subtract from minimal phenomenal selfhood to arrive at an even simpler form selfless experience and you can see in her comment on Evan Thompson in the publicly available openm um contribution that she she thinks there is an experience of pure D duration just duration as such so that the lowest level could be as you seem to imply some sort of temporal experience my intuition is rather as the Tibetan Buddhists say nness is one of the three times you know past nness and future pure awareness is timeless it doesn't even have Ness or the mere experience of duration it is an experience of timelessness and I think some of my phenomenological data seem to point into direction uh my intuition is also in that direction that there is timelessness that there actually is phenomenology of timelessness it does exist without nowness but what I don't know is how to get at this without just doing it completely bottom up with the Neuroscience of time representation you know which I still don't think we really know um no we don't I I wrote this one paper actually it was a kind of very well it's a lot shorter than the flow paper but it's an addendum to the flow paper about um the the the I'm trying to give a computational mechanism underpinning the the flow of time um uh using well kind of based off jelian phenomenology so retention Primal impression and yeah and so on um whatever the last one is pretention um I guess I guess footnote footnote I have in 1995 edited a high octane collection which is also collection which is also available in English it's called

experience and um there is a paper in there by German neuro psychologist EA Runo and mathematician um which is called time gestal and the Observer you may find that inspiring just just a footnote time the Observer should be in your library 199 oh my library is expanding all the time University Library I mean oh I see okay well maybe maybe not um okay well before we leave I'm just curious um you've been writing for a long time um and it's a very sort of marked and productive and quite remarkable career and as I said I feel like the the focus um change well not changed but it has a certain direction towards going beyond the basic smt Theory and Beyond the minimal phenomenal self to expand into epistemic self models um and then almost like a retreat back into pure awareness I'm curious just throughout the whole you know 93 up to 2024 I'm just yeah I guess I'm just curious about what is there anything you've changed your mind on is anything that sort of convinced you like oh the this part of the smt needs tweaking oh many things uh uh I sometimes play this guy game with myself is uh where was I really firmly convinced of something and uh was absolutely wrong um I give you three examples and I can go to smt um the first example is a German um how do you say tabloid press always said the terrorists of the Red Army fraction are all hiding in East Germany in Eastern Germany and I thought Ah that's just total nonsense you know that's that that's and that's where they caught them after the war came uh F down second thing is I thought it would be absolutely impossible that everybody stopped smoking I thought this would lead to large scale Rebellion and and it happened so my worldview was completely wrong so now scientifically there's a book that fortunately never came out if you read the ego tunnel which I have um after some long meditation courses in my 20s I had a few outof body experiences which also led to research and I was deeply shocked deeply shocked because I thought my my God because they were so realistic I thought my God all this new age crap this this total bizarre nonsense about the Astro body and the subtle body it's literally true and man I can't I can't talk to anybody about this there's an immortal soul and it can leave the body you know uh completely um and then I wrote to many people Charles tart and Harvey Irving and said we need to have the an edited collection start research and outof body experience and I still have no publisher took it and it was very good because it would have re ruined my academic career at the outset but there was one woman from England in there uh who and I hated her contribution Sue Blackmore oh yeah and then sue Blackmore and her husband the late Tom Treno were in Germany in tubing and she had this you know um this this theory that those were very special kind of hallucinations and Illusions and I went down to tubing and to straighten her out I I thought she was you know it's totally crazy because I had this super

realistic phenomenology and then she asked me um a question so when you've say you've moved out of your body and you've come to a stand still beside the bed what do you do then I said well maybe I go to the window sill and and try to look out and and she said so how do you do that do you fly yeah or do do you walk step by step I said ah it's kind of inde defined I think of wanting to go to the window sill and look out of the window and I'm there and she said okay what do you do next I said well I'm I'm I'm I I I go to the light switch to see if my fingers go through or if I can turn on the light switch if I'm only sleep say okay how do you get there do you walk step by step or you fly through the and I thought well it's kind of I think of the light switch and I'm there and she says see there are discontinuities this is the cognitive L map as one said at that time your brain has of your bedroom and you're just jumping from one Landmark point in your internal representation uh of your bedroom and between there is nothing and that made me think and now I think many out of body experiences are special kind of vestibular motor hallucinations and I've done research on it with friends a while ago and this I really changed my mind I really changed my mind because this was such an indubitable realistic phenomenology uh and and and Sue made me see something I didn't see in my own phenomenology I could go on no no no it's a it's it's a good one um no it's just making me think I mean one well there are three things one is that I hate to well I don't hate to but uh dor has a really nice bit on out of body experiences just for anyone who's I don't know if you've ever come across this 2010 paper I don't may not remember I have to it's nice it's a nice paper it's um myself with no body body body very good name um so that's one thing and then I guess a more well I guess a more pertinent question to the actual experience itself was you know I spoke about how sometimes I feel that when I read phenomenology I'm being duped into recognizing in my own phenomenology a phenomenological supposed fact that the writer is uh put on the page so dor was say okay in out of body experiences you always have a sense of a bodily self that's intending the objects of the experience like oh of course I mean not I've ever had one but I can imagine like oh of course I can imagine what that's like and I can imagine I'm not saying it happened I can imagine that I would have had I you know like in your case I would have an out of body experience and someone goes yeah but it was discontinuous and I go oh yeah of course it was and in and I'm again being duped into uh through some nice and I'm not accusing Sue of having an agenda or anything but I'm being duped by the questioning into Because the actual memory the kind of engram is so fuzzy because it's you know it's a I can imagine they are it you the mind is wanting to take on any you know rigid form of experience that can be labeled okay it was discontinuous did you ever

reflect on that and go am I 100% sure that her description is reflecting my phenomenon uh my phenomenological experience and also how do you contend with that generally one can if one looks at this in the f one can go on for instance predictive processing assumes there are prior one stable prior I had is it is pitch black dark night and there is no light in my bedroom I wouldn't expect anything to see anything on the way to the window sill where there was maybe a little light outside you know and I would expect total phenomenal indeterminacy on the trajectory there uh what does it really mean you know uh one can always doubt and come back uh and but what I mean this was really an example of how a body body bodily sensation structured an environment yeah you know very clearly and footnote um there are rare cases I've said it I think in one of the Mind wandering papers of aromatic body out of body first thing one has to understand there are very different kinds of body out of body experiences one you might have in a wake up phase of a catamin um after surgery may be very different from what uh Yogi in his cave in the Himalaya has you know one you have after an accident uh may be different from one you have on a Meditation Retreat they are very different and there are some people I mean I've read all that literature at the in the olden days because I was so fascinated with it there are situations where people just experience themselves as an extensionless point from which they view scene and that's a borderline case of embodiment I think one would say okay but if you're still spatially located if your visual perspective is located at some point in space above your body embodiment yeah yeah one could also [Music] say is that what we meant by a lived body you know the origin of a visual perspective and we don't have a lot of data there yeah I mean in some ways I guess it was um at the heart of your or you know that's the heart of the original definition of the MPS was that it is spacially temporally centered on the body this is yes of course of course and we I think an important distinction we made is and that has to do with your interest in egocentric uh in self-specific process uh you can have an egocentric body centered spatial spacial visual spatial model of reality that has a center but not a firstperson perspective in the epistemic sense that can be dissociated I think um and this is something you would want to doubt that anybody can have an egocentric model of reality without a know knowing self um I think it depends on what one means by epistemicity like is it is it purely a intentional relation um and we haven't even really touched upon this because there's um I I I kind of for actually many ways it started off as a rhetorical decision a clarifying decision like distinguish between an epistemic agent model and epistemic self model in this flow States paper yeah and I and and I've been thinking about why I did that and one is because I think I was using the term epistemic agency to describe

something like auto no tic Consciousness so this sense of uh pre-reflectively driving yourself through time and I think that that's C that's pretty nicely written about phenomenologically and in the cognitive science and people like um wheeler and there's a whole literature on auto no tic Consciousness that was very rich but I guess the other reason why I thought that is I thought I I've explicitly said now in the paper that uh I'm taking epistemic self models to be a or I'm Tak taking epistemic agent models to be a subset of epistemic self models yeah I think and the reason why I say that is because I think there are moments of the sense of epistemic selfhood which don't require an AG an agent yeah yeah but but it's interesting because um in your work you kind you you you know when you introduce the notion of an epistemic agent model was an epistemic agent model so do you think that um very interesting let me ask a question I know what you mean so um see say somebody sits on their cussion and does a meditation technique that scientists called open monitoring so tries to kind of effortlessly non agentively be with the whole phenomenal field not a meditation object but everything Y and um has we also assume in a thoughtless state so there's wakefulness no agentive Precision control attention whatsoever but there is an awareness of the whole thing and no thought no verification is that maybe the how say the prime candidate of the forness you're thinking about would you say that this is still for the person sitting on their cussion I would I mean I would even go beyond that and say that this is uh invol it goes even beyond the minimal phenomenal subjectivity such that involve some epistemicity such that there's a KN and I think this is important I mean I I guess the question I was also going to ask is what do we mean when we talk about the sense of a knowing self is it a knowing self that uh is agentically or agentively knowing such that it's purposefully seems to be purposefully driving itself towards some knowledge some relationship with the world or is it a um or can we disambiguate those two things so I think a canonical example here is mind wandering um I've propose I mean it's a footnote it's not particularly relevant to the question of flow but it's just in terms of getting the terminology really fixed I propose that mind wandering is an example of uh it's an Associated feature of an epistemic self model but not an epistemic agent model ah because I think you can daydream about an epis indeed indeed it it gets complex at different kinds of things but um so um if you read the introduction to the open mind collection Jenny wind and I have coined the term the phenomenal signature of knowing and we were writing about intuitions and why one should do um empirically oriented philosophy of mind without intuition mongering as we call it so we think there is a phenomenal signature of knowing for instance if you have an intuition you just have this feeling I just know this but you don't know where that knowledge comes

from now what I think this new work shows is that there can be an uncontracted phenomenal signature of knowing human brains are capable of this yes this the poor maybe Carl would have a completely deflationary reading of this you you know just that the the overall certainty or Pro probability with associated with the whole model if that is true this might be very close to what Consciousness is and it might also be close to what you are trying to find out right is isn't that it an a a phenomenal signature of knowing that is not contracted into an agent or a self is that what you mean well I guess the question is well in some sense but I guess the question therefore is could you have a minimal phenomenal self without uh without it becoming an epistemic self model yeah you can of course you can but then but then in some sense that that then the knowing the signature of knowing would not be at the heart of Consciousness because you would have a paradigmatic case of Consciousness without the sense of knowing well if it is basically the bodily here and now which is a very common the Here and Now is a very common meditation experience it be that the presence of a signature of knowing kind of falls out of it or naturally reveals it in in that kind of state of just being no would it be would it be a necessary concomitant could you imagine that there is a pure here there's a bit where I talk about again this is just I I think actually I'm just going to point people in the direction of the paper because I have really thought about this and I guess it's not been in explicit terms in like a conversation like this but it's just been trying to demarcate these categories um that I don't think the distinction between the uh I take the minimal phenomenal self here to just be identical to what I've been calling pre-reflective self-awareness I know the ontological commitments are different but it was just easier um and I make that clear but I I make it very clear therefore that I don't think that um there's a strict distinction between an epistemic self model and a phen minimal phenomenal self because a minimal phenomenal self can have this signature of knowing as you said um but it makes me wonder whether you can have like is that signature of knowing an add-on a build you know an extra layer to Pure subjectivity or is it imminent in the subjectivity I can I do not know uh I can only share with you the way I'm trying to frame it now a living organism with a nervous system opens an epistemic space um and this epistemic space can maybe even extend across the boundaries of the body and some kinds of active inference and so on and so forth but an organism is only conscious I think the essence of being conscious is to have a model of that space to know that you many ways to tell this to know that you are an embodied epistemic space and this significance of pure awareness experiences and like this is that you can well you can stabilize the model of your own epistemic space and it's not transparent anymore it becomes opaque

you can notice it and become aware of it um that's that's part of the interesting thing so I would say there's a space in that space many different epistemic uh Poss uh states can happen in our own case most of them coded as properties of a knowing self that knows but that's not a necessary condition some systems in some situations can model the space as such in an uncentered way and then you get this pure signature of knowing I mean you maybe you would find there's a chapter on witness Consciousness maybe You' find that helpness helpful um I don't I don't know that's how the way I'm trying to frame this so a patient in vegetative coma in unresponsive wakefulness syndrome certainly has an epistemic space it knows how to breathe how not to die there are gaze following movements and stuff like this but it's entirely unconscious because it has no model of its own epistemic space the organism doesn't know that it has up opened an epistemic space same thing when you wake up in the morning I claim that most people know what pure awareness is but never pay attention to it it may be the first 200 300 500 milliseconds of the waking up process in morning where you come to but you don't know who you are you don't know where you are you don't know what place you are in you're disoriented to place time and person as a psychiatrist would be but Wide Awake that is the system which you are is just booting its model of the epistemic base and a second later you know there will be the bedroom and it will be filled with content but the in the budha process there's a short period where there is just a model of wakefulness per se of becoming epistemically open to the world that's how I would like to or try to frame it but I don't know if it's correct no well it sounds well in my experience there's certainly that um that that that chimes with my intuitions or at least you know my fake Recollections of that I mean I think you also get that sometimes where you wake up from a very deep you know not even in the morning I mean I think actually you get a more protracted experience of that sometimes in the middle in is that the two first 200 milliseconds is there forness the thing you're trying to get after I still kind I still think there is but is has anyone done any qualitative work on this on the first few seconds well I think don't know what um just for the audience and for myself actually what you know the one where you talked about the pure signature of knowing do you recall which the name of that paper yeah it's freely away aivable in the internet uh it's open minus mind net the open mind collection and it's in the introduction it's in an introduction you can download it oh what does it mean to have an open mind excellent lovely yeah I think I have to have lunch now no have lunch didn't you know what we didn't even touch upon the PMI R but I think that's for part two um we were touching upon it then but it's for another time I cuz I've got a slight I've got a slight thing to pick with the PMI but I'm not going to get into it now

because you've got lunch um Thomas yeah I'm going to need a nap lunch a bath I don't know what I'm going to need to do this I'm GNA need to take a moment but this was tremendous fun I mean it was tremendous fun for me I really hope everyone it's you know your work is just so terrific the depth the Lucidity tackling really I think probably the most fundamental questions that there are um in a astute robust way is like it it really is something quite incredible so thank you so much for taking the time uh to speak to me was very nice talking to you the elephant and the blind is out now so people should pick that up and read it and as you say it's open access um I always like to just give people a minute at the end just to speak about anything else that they've got going on slash where people can find them um you know email wise Twitter whatever you want well I have an an Old English website at the University of Minds which you can find through Wikipedia page trying to build a new one doesn't doesn't work um I don't know the most important thing for me at this stage is that I've just worked very hard for 40 years I'm now retired and I really don't want to work hard anymore congratulations and you might want to is any anything you want to say about the foundation or the competition that's currently open anything like that yeah maybe you you want to post this um if you're interested in the MP project there's a a website now MP minus pro.info and you find a lot of stuff and material there and there's a price that with British scientists uh like Carl and anneal uh in the in the jury and by 31st of September we look for um formal models for the computational phenomenology of MP of pure awareness so if anybody wants to win 20,000 Euros look at that come on guys yeah yeah I'm I'm I'm still thinking I'm still thinking I I got to read the book first um completely again so much fun so much gratitude um thank you so much again for me and The Institute uh it's been a real pleasure same here uh good luck with it all thanks thas thanks great